

ASSIGNMENT 1: MANAGING
DIVERSE WORKPLACES

Assignment 1 – Managing Diverse Workplaces – xxxxxx Pty Ltd

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Company Introduction & Overview

The organisation I have chosen to analyse with respect to Diversity, Equity and Inclusion is xxxxxx Pty Ltd. xxxxxx is an Australian company that operates primarily in the industries of energy and energy distribution, alongside agriculture and other verticals being explored. Within these industries they offer IoT products which enable customers, being both large businesses and end users, the ability to monitor their liquid assets, and optimise their operations through hardware, software, and cloud-based service offerings.

xxxxxx is a relatively small team in the scale-up phase of their organisational journey. This is important to note when assessing the company, irrespective of the focus of any analysis. It is noted by Adizes (2004) that formal structures such as established policies, systems and procedures can be lacking when an organisation is in and coming out of infancy.

Being in year 7 of the company's evolution, it is a good time to look at how DEI principles are functioning within xxxxxx, particularly as it looks to expand operations internationally, with a global strategy. Given the documented positive outcomes when operating globally for diverse workplaces, as noted by McKinsey & Company (2022), there may be scope for xxxxxx to gain a competitive advantage by improving this aspect of their business.

Diversity in the Workplace Basics

Diversity has a different meaning to different people, and as such has a different meaning, or definition in different organisations. Through this draft, a definition of diversity will be created to give context to future undertakings throughout.

To see how xxxxxx currently assesses, addresses, and measures diversity, there should be some attempt to break down the organisation, at a surface level, with some basic diversity markers. These noted differences are definitely of a narrow definition and are not an attempt to create an understanding of diversity, but, as a starting point merely show the level of representational diversity within xxxxxx.

Number of Team Members (including board members) – 19

Males – 14, Females – 5

Nationalities represented – 11

The industries in which xxxxxx operates are traditionally male dominated, which is reflected in the numbers of males and females within the company. Women “account for one in five energy positions” (International Energy Agency, n.d.) with women in leadership positions in the sector being at a slightly lower level again. The IEA is an organisation which has a gender equity taskforce amongst other initiatives, so there is a conscious effort to modernise, reflecting an understanding across the industry that greater balance is needed. Statistically, xxxxxx could be said to be doing better in this area, however it is only by a few percentage points.

Additional points of note which could relate to diversity at xxxxxx are relevant in creating a big picture view within the context of this course. The 3 board members consist of two males and one female, with the Chairperson being male. The 4 founders of the company are all male and are represented by 4 nationalities, American, New Zealand, Chinese, and Ukranian.

With what is a clear bias towards a male workforce, albeit unintentional, there would be good reason to think about a narrow definition of diversity, with a view to measure diversity performance at xxxxxx. As stated, energy and agriculture are traditionally male dominated industries, so actions to create a more even workforce seem logical. xxxxxx is an equal opportunity employer, which “ensures equal consideration, not preferential hiring” (Hays-Thomas, 2022, p. 5).

The Fair Work Act prohibits workplace discrimination based on protected attributes such as race, sex, age, disability, religion, pregnancy, and other listed grounds (Fair Work Ombudsman, n.d.). It is fair to say that xxxxxx is merely acting lawfully in its overall diversity actions.

There exist no formal structures, policies, systems, or processes at xxxxxx to address or measure diversity, or the as important factors of equity and inclusion. Of course, there are no discriminatory behaviours, but the opportunity to do better, as well as gain a competitive advantage is potentially being missed.

In a small organisation like xxxxxx, measuring diversity on its own is undoubtedly less valuable than when it is measured alongside equity, inclusion and belonging. This should be the focus when working toward a development plan and recommendations based on the assessment undertaken. Quantitative data is more valuable when paired with qualitative data and will allow for greater understanding of the subject as a whole.

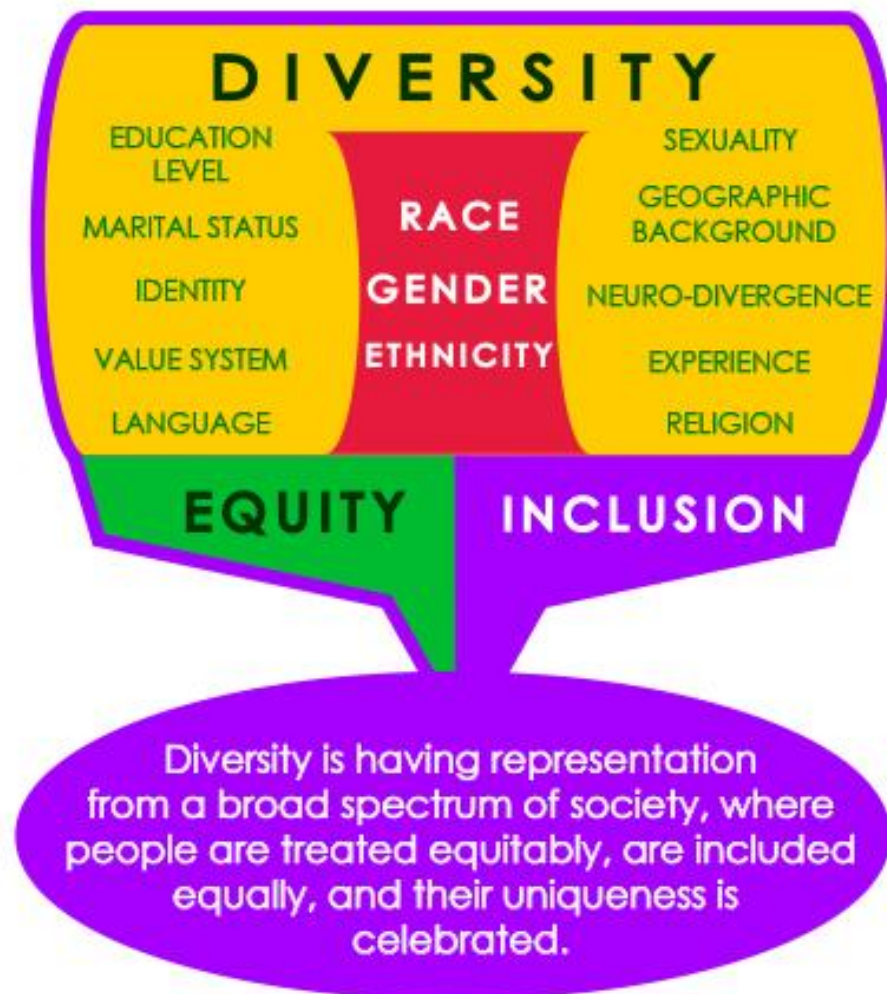
Research by Gartner led to 7 key dimensions of inclusion, “fair treatment, integrating differences, decision-making, psychological safety, trust, belonging, and diversity” (Romansky et al., 2021). This has me believe that diversity is tied to inclusion, and therefore assessed and measured together, rather than separately. Employee feedback via pulse surveys can begin to capture this data.

Leading Workplace Diversity

Leading true workplace diversity means that a broader definition of diversity needs to be considered. Beyond just visible differences, one needs to understand there are more invisible differences that prevalent within society, and potentially, or more likely probably, within your workplace. Don't assume everyone is like you.

Figure 1.

Definition of Diversity



Invisible diversity has a deeper list than seen in figure 1, however, for leading diversity at xxxxxx, the above shows a mix of narrowly defined meanings of diversity, which can serve to highlight traditional inequities of representation within energy and agriculture industries, as well as invisible differences such as education level, identity, and experience. A funnel of equity and inclusion leads to the definition of diversity, which is where leadership becomes pronounced, as it creates belonging, signified by a purple border surrounding all.

Leaders can benefit from a clear understanding of what DEI means within the organisation, and where it sits with respect to its maturity as a diverse organisation, as effectively leading diverse workplaces requires a combination of deliberate behavioral considerations, as well as structures, processes, and organizational policies, to guide the leadership.

Does a leader, more specifically, does the leadership at xxxxxx need to be more proactive when it comes to diversity. Hays-Thomas (2022, Figure 2.1) presents a questionnaire to establish where an organisation might be in terms of diversity. For xxxxxx, the answers show elements of having diversity maturity, but also shows a lack of deliberate consideration of diversity.

Hays-Thomas (2022) asks whether management believes they will achieve greater innovation and ideas if they hire people who are different from those already within the organisation. I think at xxxxxx, the executive team do have a mantra of looking for diverse talent, but without a particular policy stating this. As outlined earlier, the founders, although all male, have different backgrounds, and I see various ethnicities and backgrounds within the current team.

Within the small team at xxxxxx, it is also fair to say that people of different ethnicities are employed at all levels through the company.

If I were looking for more from leadership with respect to diversity, it would be to have greater female representation. This could be an area where xxxxxx could look to create something formal in terms of policy. The 5 women within the xxxxxx team do have positions that show there is every

opportunity to grow and progress – Board member, Director of LPG sales, Head of Operations, Head of Agbot Sales, and Customer Support. More evenness throughout the company could be something to address.

With differences that fall within the broader definition of diversity, I don't think a company as small as xxxxxx can do too much more, I believe a culture of equity and inclusion is what is required to make diversity an intrinsic part of the company.

To ingrain diversity and inclusion, I think xxxxxx would benefit from creating something official. "Formalizing company values in explicit language can help make culture real inside an organization" (Meyer, 2024).

Leading Workplace Equity

Equity in the workplace enables diversity to mean something. There is little value in having a wide variety of people from different backgrounds, ethnicities, experiences and values if only a select few, or type, have access to all available opportunities.

“Equity-minded managers understand that transparency through sharing key information with all team members is just the first step because equity comes from making sure everyone understands that information.” (Miranda-Wolff, 2024, p. 6). This statement has great meaning as it alludes to what true equity looks like. In a practical example, a company may have gym facilities available to all employees, but if only a certain type, or level of employee, is seen to be using the facilities, a barrier may still exist, which can inhibit a sense of belonging.

There are some noteworthy practices that occur that show equity at xxxxxx. These are not rooted in DEI principles but do show management being proactive in the space of equity.

On a monthly basis a facilitator takes a session where there is the opportunity for all employees to submit potential improvement points (PIPs). These can be submitted anonymously or named. They are categorised and given weight, dependent on a vote by all members. Some PiPs are larger than others and may take significant consideration, others are easier to tackle, nonetheless all are recorded and there is a commitment to improve on each of these points. Individuals from all levels in the company take leadership over small groups to work on different PiPs. One's position within the company is irrelevant within these activities and all levels of the team can take ownership of a PiP. Completed PiPs are celebrated.

Within the organisation, there could undoubtedly be some simple steps taken to advance equity. As stated earlier, xxxxxx is now in its 7th year of development and has grown out of its start-up phase. There are however some lingering effects. Start-up companies are commonly moving quickly

from one state to the next trying to create a profitable organisation from scratch. Along the way, important things are missed. Now is time for xxxxxx to address some of these misses.

Thorough documentation, particularly on-boarding kits, FAQs, company policies must be available for all employees in any organisation. It is unfair to expect a diverse range of people to have the same level of understanding of specific computer systems, naming conventions, file storage locations, product knowledge etc. Without proper and considered training for all employees, it can easily become an inequitable workplace. xxxxxx needs to address this.

Another aspect, where xxxxxx could look to provide more equity, is to consider the male to female ratio in the company, noted in the section on diversity. At xxxxxx, when looking specifically within product development and software development, there are 6 males and zero females.

“Equity recognizes that advantages exist disproportionately, and as a result we don’t all start from the same place.” (Ike, 2023, p. 39) Looking more closely at hiring processes could be seen as managing diversity, however, I believe that as a group sees more balance, without a particular bias to a particular group, equity is more easily achieved, alongside belonging.

Conclusion

To this point, Managing Diverse Workplaces has allowed me to look at xxxxxx through a different lens, of which there had been little consideration previously.

As the course continues, I am looking forward to taking the ideas and observations up to now, and those which develop in the coming weeks, and really refining them into a more actionable set of systems and processes, which could be used at xxxxxx, as well as taken on board at other organisations.

It has been a challenge to separate diversity and equity from inclusion and belonging, so I look forward to seeing them more holistically, but also recognize the importance of understanding each on their own.

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